

Through his NGO Robin Raina Foundation, Robin Raina (center) is making some under-privileged people's dreams come true.

dwellers, on legal land, with the goal of removing the word slum completely from the area . Fast forward to today – 2,304 Concrete homes have been built by Robin's foundation and handed over free of cost to the under-privileged inhabitants. *What could have been the second largest slum in Asia, after Dharavi, has become 30% slum free today.*

Not only did the Foundation build these homes, but the Foundation also created a eco-system for the 150,000 poor inhabitants in the area. They set up schools for the underprivileged children while providing education, healthcare, clothes, meals, sports activities etc. besides providing vocational training to the teenage girls and older women with the goal of getting them occupational independence. The Foundation set up Self Help Groups for women wherein they could pool their resources and support each other financially, besides providing micro-credit and healthcare to the inhabitants there.

Having constructed and handed over 2304 homes, Robin is still committed to building the remaining homes to complete the target of 6000 homes and make the area totally slum free.

This inspiring story of Change and development in the lives of the under-privileged has another story hidden in it. That is the story of a patriotic Non-resident Indian Robin Raina, who built a gigantic business in the West, but decided to come back to his roots in India to make a difference in the lives of the have-nots. His mission – "I want to make charity fashionable and cool, so that everyone including the youth embrace it." With 50% Indians below the age of 25, he believes that the youth must play a big role in reducing the gulf between the rich and the poor.

Najmum Nisha, a Bawana resident said, "*I am 85 years old and suffer from multiple ailments. Not only did the Foundation build two homes for my family and my daughter's family, it also gave me monetary compensation every month for my medical treatment. I consider Robin as my God gifted son and will always be looking out for him even when I am in my grave.*"

The journey for the Foundation was not easy. It had to fight adversity on many fronts. On one hand, there were top city politicians fighting Foundation efforts since they were concerned whether Robin was building a vote bank for an eventual political goal and on the other side were calamities like constant made-made fires, rampant disease, lack of any drainage or healthcare in the area. It was a struggle for imparting a sense of identity to people who didn't seemingly exist for the administration. Fighting all these odds, the Foundation has now spent 19 years working to uplift the lives of the inhabitants of Bawana in Delhi. Inspiring? Wait, there's more! Robin's efforts were not just limited to Bawana. Today, the foundation supports the education of thousands of children every year across the country, runs multiple schools across India, has built an orphan home for underprivileged girls in Mumbai, runs medical ambulances and supports the education of hundreds of underprivileged blind children through Masters program in reputed Universities.

"Charity knows no boundaries of region, color, sex, language, religion or race. In fact, I believe that poverty is the single biggest religion in the world. Towards that extent, the foundation today supports projects across regions irrespective of religion or race." This effort has taken the foundation's activities to helping cancer effected children in Pakistan, to building homes for tornado impacted under-privileged farmer families in Alabama, to adopting 1300 fisherman families in the tsunami ravaged villages in Kotilpadu and Pudur in South of India.

A recent project has been a wealth exchange initiative "Yogdaan" to take donations in kind from the rich and provide it to the under-privileged through a supermarket mall set up just for the underprivileged, with each donation being bar tagged and tracked online for the donor until it reaches the named under-privileged. One such fully operational mall is in Ashok Vihar, and has been set up a joint charity initiative with another charity Sewa Bharati.

In 2010 Commonwealth Games, India won 101 medals, the best performance till date, but unknown to the nation, it came at the cost of sufferings to innumerable under-privileged families. Unsung heroes like Robin Raina continue to work behind the scenes to bring smiles to children, who could churn out our next Neeraj Chopra or Mithali Raj! *It's time to encourage and celebrate the real heroes*!

6000 Homes

